# Sonakshi Agrawal

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*As of October 23, 2026*

## EDUCATION

**Columbia Business School, Columbia University** — *New York, NY*
PhD Candidate in Accounting — *2022 – Present*

**Indian School of Business** — *Hyderabad, India*
FPM Student (PhD Equivalent) – Passed Qualifier Exam — *2020 – 2022*

**Indian Institute of Management, Lucknow** — *Lucknow, India*
PGDM (MBA Equivalent) — *2016 – 2018*

**Christ College** — *Bengaluru, India*
B.Com (Honors) — *2013 – 2016*

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

Sustainability, Energy Sector, Regulatory Accounting, Corporate Governance

## JOB MARKET PAPER

**Cash Now, Current Later: Energy Investment in the AI Era**

*Presented at Emerging Scholars in Accounting 2026, Frankfurt School of Finance and Management*

The data centers behind artificial intelligence are raising U.S. electricity demand after a decade of flat growth. Several states have responded by reviving Construction Work in Progress (CWIP), a cost-recovery rule that lets a utility begin collecting from customers while an asset is still being built rather than only after it enters service. Using the historical wave of state-level CWIP adoptions in a staggered difference-in-differences design, I find that utilities build more and finish construction faster once their state allows CWIP. I find that CWIP eases financing through the terms on which utilities borrow, not the cash they retain. The investment response is larger where the expected payoff to investing is higher. Looking beyond investment, the data do not suggest customers are better served. In the current wave, CWIP states are already planning far more customer-funded capacity than states without the rule, where new building is left to independent producers. These results contribute to the emerging literature on financing the infrastructure demands of artificial intelligence.

## ACADEMIC PUBLICATIONS AND FORTHCOMING PAPERS

1. **"ESG Ratings of ESG Index Providers"**
   (with Lisa Liu, Shiva Rajgopal, Suhas A. Sridharan, Yifan (Eva) Yan, and Teri Lombardi Yohn)
   *Forthcoming at The Accounting Review*
   *Note:* This paper integrates two earlier working papers: "ESG Ratings of ESG Index Providers" by Agrawal, Liu, and Rajgopal, and "ESG Rating Agency Incentives" by Sridharan, Yan, and Yohn.

   The paper asks whether index-licensing incentives contribute to disagreement across ESG ratings. We find that raters with stronger licensing incentives assign higher ESG ratings to firms they add to their ESG indexes, particularly when those firms have strong stock-return performance, even after controlling for fundamental ESG performance and differences in rating methodology.

## WORKING PAPERS

1. **"Who Bears Climate Risk? Differential Impacts on Public and Private Firms"**
(with Lisa Liu and Shiva Rajgopal)
*Accepted at Review of Accounting Studies (RAST) 2026 Conference*
*Previously Titled "Follow the Money: Are Severe Weather Events Value Relevant?"*

   The paper examines how private firms, which fall outside the scope of most climate-disclosure regulation, respond to climate disasters relative to the public firms these rules target. We find that private firms experience persistent sales declines while public firms show no measurable operating effect. Geographic diversification and access to credit each explain part of the gap, but neither protects firms in capital-intensive industries that cannot easily relocate production.

2. **"Do Public Firms Prioritize Domestic Shareholders Over Foreign Stakeholders? Evidence from Regulatory Arbitration"**
(with Anthony Le and Lisa Liu)

   Corporations increasingly use investor-state dispute settlement (ISDS) to challenge foreign regulations through international arbitration, raising concerns about corporate influence over policymaking. We ask whether public firms use this channel differently from private firms. We find public firms are more likely to challenge industry-wide regulations, with effects strongest where shareholder protections are strong and for stakeholder-protective regulations, suggesting public firms use ISDS in ways that favor domestic shareholders over foreign stakeholders.

3. **"Unveiling Influence: Mandatory Disclosure of Voting Rationale"**
(with Sumeet Rajput)
*Received Bernstein Center Doctoral Research Grant (Columbia Business School)*
*Selected for Corporate Governance: An International Review (CGIR) Paper Development Workshop 2026*

   The paper examines how mandatory disclosure of voting rationales reshapes institutional voting and firm governance, using a 2014 Indian mandate that requires mutual funds to justify every vote. We find that abstentions fall by about a quarter, with dissent concentrated in auditor approvals, executive compensation, and director appointments. Disclosure quality is overwhelmingly a fund-level decision rather than a firm characteristic. Treated firms reduce CEO duality, busy directorships, and dividends, while raising board financial expertise.

## WORK IN PROGRESS

1. **Impact of Climate Risk Disclosure on Insurance Industry** (solo authored)
Investigates how mandated climate risk disclosure affects insurers' underwriting decisions.

2. **Financial Analysis in Inflationary Times: A Study on Adjusted Reporting and Asset Pricing Factors** (solo authored)
Tests whether inflation-adjusted financial reporting improves explanatory power of accounting-based asset pricing factors and analyst forecast accuracy.

## AWARDS, FELLOWSHIPS & GRANTS

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| Bernstein Center Doctoral Research Grant (CBS) | 2025 |
| Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award (CBS) | 2025 |
| FARS Midyear Meeting Outstanding Discussion Award | 2025 |
| FARS Excellence in Reviewing Award | 2025 |
| Paul and Sandra Montrone Scholarship (CBS) | 2023, 2026 |
| Columbia Business School Doctoral Fellowship | 2022 – Present |
| ISB FPM Fellowship | 2020 – 2022 |
| Amritkala Dayal Scholarship (IIM Lucknow) | 2016 – 2018 |
| Best Research Paper during B.Com (Honors) | 2016 |
| Merit Scholarship – Christ College | 2016 |

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

**Columbia University – Instructor**

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| Accounting & Finance for Economics (Undergraduate) | Summer 2025 |

**Columbia University – Teaching Assistant**

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| MS Finance Thesis (Masters) | Spring 2025 |
| Fundamental Analysis for Investors, Managers & Entrepreneurs (MBA) | Fall 2024, 2025 |
| Financial Accounting (MBA) | Fall 2023–24; Spring 2024–26 |
| PhD Research on Investing with Fundamental Analysis (Masters) | Spring 2024 |
| Measuring & Managing Climate Risk (MBA) | Fall 2023 |
| Finance & Accounting (PEPM) | Summer 2023, 2026 |
| Financial Statement Analysis & Valuation (MBA) | Spring 2023 |

**ISB Hyderabad – Teaching Assistant**

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|---|---|
| Financial Accounting in Decision Making (Masters) | 2021 |
| Hedge Funds and their Trading Strategies (Masters) | 2021 |
| Microeconomics A (FPM) | 2021 |
| Microeconomics B (FPM) | 2022 |

**Other**

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|---|---|
| Financial Reporting and Analysis – Tutor (PGDM, IIM Lucknow) | 2018 |

## CONFERENCE PARTICIPATION

**Forthcoming**

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| Journal of Accounting and Economics (JAE) Conference | Nov 2026 |
| Review of Accounting Studies (RAST) Conference | Dec 2026 |

**Past**

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| Ethics Symposium (Centre for Accounting Ethics, University of Waterloo)* | 2026 |
| Emerging Scholars in Accounting (Frankfurt School of Finance and Management)* | 2026 |
| European Accounting Association – Annual Congress*^ | 2026 |
| Four-School Accounting Research Conference# | 2026 |
| Trans-Atlantic Doctoral Conference (TADC)*^ | 2025 |
| Columbia Accounting Theory Conference | 2025–26 |
| Current Issues in Sustainability: Human Capital, AI, Disclosure Quality, and More! (AAA)*^ | 2025 |
| Financial Accounting and Reporting Section Midyear Meeting*^# | 2025 |
| CARE Conference: Accountability in a Sustainable World* | 2024 |
| Eastern Finance Association Annual Meeting*^ | 2024 |
| Baruch Climate and Sustainability/ESG Conference | 2024 |
| Hawai'i Accounting Research Conference (HARC)*^ | 2024 |
| Columbia Junior Accounting Faculty Conference | 2024–26 |
| Columbia Management Accounting Conference | 2024–26 |
| Burton Accounting Conference (CBS) | 2022–26 |
| Conference on Corporate Social Responsibility*^# | 2023 |
| ISB Accounting Research Conference | 2021 |

*Presenter ^Discussant #Moderator

## SERVICE

**Ad Hoc Reviewer – Journals**

Journal of Accounting and Economics

**Ad Hoc Reviewer – Conferences**

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| Hawai'i Accounting Research Conference (HARC) | 2027 |
| AAA Financial Accounting and Reporting Section Midyear Meeting | 2024–27 |
| ARCS (Alliance for Research on Corporate Sustainability) Annual Conference | 2025–26 |
| International Corporate Governance Society (ICGS) Conference | 2026 |
| AAA Current Issues in Sustainability: Human Capital, AI, Disclosure Quality | 2025 |
| AAA Annual Meeting | 2024–25 |
| AAA Sustainability, ESG, and Accounting Meeting | 2023 |

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

**Center for Teacher Accreditation**, Bengaluru — Jan 2020 – Jul 2020
*Intern – Product Management*

**Avendus Wealth Management**, Mumbai — Apr 2018 – Nov 2019
*Associate – Products*

**Deutsche CIB Centre**, Mumbai — Apr 2017 – May 2017
*Intern – ANZ Credit Team*

**Goldman Sachs**, Bengaluru — Apr 2015 – May 2015
*Intern – Data Resource (Investment Banking)*

**SBI Mutual Funds**, Roorkee — Apr 2014 – May 2014
*Intern – Marketing*

## OTHER PUBLICATION

1. **"Credit Rating Agencies' Assessments of Related Party Transactions"**
   (with Hariom Manchiraju & Sumeet Rajput)
   *Accounting Theory and Practice*, Vol. 2, 2025

## REFERENCES


**Shiva Rajgopal**
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Columbia Business School
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**Jon Glover**
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**Lisa Liu**
Associate Professor
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